

“Over the last decades, the beach has retreated to where the shoreline is at their doorstep. ... Nourishment has become a crutch. What are you buying that time to do?”

Reide Corbett, an oceanographer and the executive director of the Coastal Studies Institute at East Carolina University



DANIEL PULLEN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Cullen Gaskill removes a wire from an erosion-threatened house in Buxton, North Carolina, in October.

One afternoon in late October, as Lat Williams stood near the roiling ocean, he called his wife, Debby.

“I think we’re going to lose the house,” he told her. “I think it’s going down within the hour.”

For weeks, they had watched with dread as the ocean claimed their neighbors’ homes along this erosion-battered stretch of beach, where once-towering dunes have been leveled, entire sections of streets have disappeared and at least 19 homes have collapsed since September.

At their place on Cottage Avenue, the clawing surf had left their septic system exposed. Floating debris knocked out part of their foundation, and the churning tides sent water rushing under the house.

“Suddenly, we were beach-front,” Lat, 71, recalled.

Losing battle to save N.C. beach homes

Numerous collapses have forced hard questions about what to protect — or leave to the waves

BY BRADY DENNIS, JOHN MUYSKENS, KEVIN CROWE AND DANIEL PULLEN
IN BUXTON, N.C.

“We were *on* the beach,” said Debby, 68. “We were *in* the beach.”

It wasn’t always this way. Debby still has a photo from the day her parents bought the home back in 1980, the two of them smiling beside a “for sale” sign. Healthy dunes and hundreds of feet of beach stretched out behind them then.

Four generations have enjoyed the modest cottage, where Lat and Debby retired and have lived full time since 2017.

“I always wanted to live here,” Debby said. “I love the ocean, even when she tries to do us in.”

Survey data obtained by The Washington Post from RCOAST, a company that uses aerial 3D mapping, reveals how tides began to encroach on the homes of the Williamses’ neighbors as Hurricane Erin passed offshore

SEE BUXTON ON A10

Trump pauses mission to clear path in Hormuz

AN ABRUPT REVERSAL SOON AFTER STARTING

He wants space for ‘finalized’ deal; blockade goes on

BY TARA COPP, DAN LAMOTHE, VICTORIA CRAW AND CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.

President Donald Trump said late Tuesday that he was pausing the military’s new operation to clear a transit path through the Strait of Hormuz for commercial vessels, halting a mission that had only just begun, even as more than 1,500 commercial ships are still waiting to get through Iran’s closure of the critical waterway.

Trump said the pause “comes at the request of Pakistan and other countries,” and means that U.S. military operations, including using warships to clear a path through the strait, will be halted “for a short period of time to see whether or not the [peace] agreement can be finalized and signed,” Trump wrote in a social media post.

In the immediate term, that means that while the U.S. Navy’s interdictions of ships that have entered Iranian ports will continue, the air- and sea-based operations to clear the strait for commercial vessels are now on hold, Trump said. Both sides have exchanged fire in the past day over the strait.

A spokesperson for U.S. Central Command, which is responsible for the transit clearing and the ongoing blockade, referred questions on the pause back to the White House.

Trump’s announcement follows two news conferences Tuesday, one at the Pentagon and one at the White House, where the administration touted the effectiveness of the new military operation

SEE IRAN ON A18

Timeline: Trump keeps changing when he’ll end the Iran war. **A4**

A push to break silence on Israel’s nuclear arms

House Democrats want U.S. public admission of decades-long open secret

BY JOHN HUDSON

A group of House Democrats is urging the Trump administration to publicly acknowledge Israel’s undeclared nuclear weapons program, a move that would abandon decades of U.S. policy but confirm what has been an open secret among intelligence officials since the late 1960s.

In a letter to Secretary of State Marco Rubio obtained by The Washington Post, more than two

dozen lawmakers, led by Rep. Joaquin Castro (Texas), say Washington’s silence on the program is indefensible amid the war in Iran and the acute threat of military escalation.

“The risks of miscalculation, escalation, and nuclear use in this environment are not theoretical,” the lawmakers wrote. “Congress has a constitutional responsibility to be fully informed about the nuclear balance in the Middle East, the risk of escalation by any party to this conflict, and the administration’s planning and contingencies for such scenarios.”

“We do not believe we have received that information,” the lawmakers wrote.

SEE ISRAEL ON A18

\$1B offer for White House fans flames of ballroom fray

BY DAN DIAMOND, JONATHAN EDWARDS AND RILEY BEGGIN

Senate Republicans late Monday proposed \$1 billion to pay for new White House security measures, with lawmakers and White House officials disagreeing over whether the legislation would cover President Donald Trump’s planned ballroom.

Sen. Chuck Grassley (R-Iowa), chairman of the Senate Judiciary Committee, laid out a funding package for security upgrades related to the “East Wing Modernization Project,” the Trump administration’s name for its planned 90,000-square-foot project to rebuild the East Wing that Trump demolished last year.

The proposed legislative text says the money would be used for both aboveground and underground security features that the administration has declined to fully detail. The text explicitly says the money could not be used

SEE BALLROOM ON A2

‘The whole system failed Kamryn’



CAROLINE GUTMAN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

The family of 24-year-old Kamryn Jones, who is blind and can barely speak, is suing her group home, caregivers and state agencies after her pregnancy revealed her rape. Jones gave birth to a healthy baby girl, above, in 2024. **Story, B13**

New focus on abortion gives a political opening

Amid legal threat to mifepristone, Democrats see an opportunity

BY PRAVEENA SOMASUNDARAM AND RACHEL ROUBEIN

Democrats, who retreated from their focus on abortion rights after losing the White House in 2024, see an opportunity to go back on the offensive after a federal court temporarily curbed access last week.

Abortion rights advocates are hoping to capitalize on the legal uncertainty, as they did when scoring a string of Democratic victories in the 2022 midterms shortly after the Supreme Court overturned *Roe v. Wade*.

On Friday, a federal appeals court severely curbed abortion access when it required women to get an abortion pill in person rather than by mail. Activists called the decision the biggest attack on reproductive rights since *Roe*’s fall. A Supreme Court

justice on Monday then restored mail access to the drug, mifepristone — for one week.

Democrats with presidential aspirations are raising alarms while congressional candidates in competitive districts have stayed relatively quiet, a sign that the party is still figuring out how to react. Advocates view the legal scuffle over the pill as a fresh opening for Democrats to take abortion off the back burner and capitalize on the issue as they look to win back majorities in Congress.

The full fate of access to mifepristone, the most widely used abortion pill, hangs in the balance. Medication abortion is the most common method for terminating pregnancies, and mail delivery made it accessible even in states with abortion bans. The new legal limbo adds urgency to an issue that had lost its potency and was overtaken by affordability concerns.

“Reproductive freedom is not safe,” said Mini Timmaraju, president of the national abortion rights group Reproductive Freedom for All. “And moments like

SEE ABORTION ON A2

IN THE NEWS

Four felonies A federal grand jury in D.C. indicted the suspect in the White House media dinner shooting, including a charge of attempted presidential assassination. **B13**

Title IX investigation One of the nation’s most well-known women’s colleges faces a federal probe for admitting trans students. **A4**

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The EEOC has sued the New York Times, citing DEI for a White man’s denial of promotion. **A7**
The president leveled new criticism at Pope Leo ahead of Marco Rubio’s trip to Rome. **A9**

THE WORLD

A growing cohort of women on Instagram and TikTok are giving rare, unmoderated views into daily life in Cuba amid the island’s worst crisis in decades from a fuel embargo. **A8**

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Despite a low-income household, this grandmother provided a master class in money management, Michelle Singletary writes. **A14**

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An explosive lawsuit between Blake Lively and Justin Baldoni over the film “It Ends With Us” has been settled. **B1**

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Top-ranked Aryna Sabalenka said tennis players should boycott if they don’t get bigger cuts of Grand Slam profits. **B7**

THE REGION

A union representing Kennedy Center workers accused the institution of violating a labor contract to gut jobs. **B13**

FOOD

Sour foods can unlock a world of flavor: Fermented, pickled ingredients add a fresh and tangy edge.

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